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THE EXPANDING STRUGGLE

History has thrust upon our generation an indescribably important destiny—to complete a process of democratization which our nation has too long developed too slowly, but which is our most powerful weapon for world respect and emulation. How we deal with this crucial situation will determine our moral health as individuals, our cultural health as a region, our political health as a nation, and our prestige as a leader of the free world.

FEBRUARY 14, 1957
King becomes head of Southern Leaders Conference (later SCLC)

MAY 17
Delivers address at Prayer Pilgrimage for Freedom in Washington, D.C.

SEPTEMBER 25
Applauds President Eisenhower's decision to use force to integrate Little Rock's Central High School

OCTOBER 23
Martin Luther King III is born

JUNE 23, 1958
King and other civil rights leaders meet with Eisenhower

On January 9, 1957, Ralph Abernathy and I went to Atlanta to prepare for a meeting of Negro leaders that I had called for the following day. In the middle of the night we were awakened by a telephone call from Ralph's wife, Juanita. I knew that only some new disaster would make her rouse us at two in the morning. When Ralph came back, his sober face told part of the story. "My home has been bombed," he said, "and three or four other explosions have been heard in the city, but Juanita doesn't know where yet." I asked about Juanita and their daughter. "Thank God, they are safe." Before we could talk any more, the telephone rang a second time. It was